Core 90 - Binary search

4 questions to study here, each on its own page, with the full interview answer and code

Nothing to skip: every question that fits this topic is covered here

4
MEDIUM

How to use

- Questions run from Easy to Medium to Hard, newest last-asked date first inside each level.
- PDFs run from the one with the most questions to the fewest. A question has pages in only one PDF; the others list it as SKIP
- Every page has < Prev | Contents | Next > at the bottom. Tap a title in the Contents to jump to it.
- Select code and press Cmd/Ctrl+C to copy it.

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STUDY PATH: question 59 of 167 (Core 90)

Priority score 4.28 | Binary search | asked 65 days ago | frequency Single report

MEDIUM | 1Point3Acres | onsite-coding | 1 of 4

Cutting Ribbons (LC 1891)

ASKED 2026-08-16 | 65 DAYS AGO | LAST 90 DAYS

STUDY: TALK | **ALL TIME 19.6** | **30 DAYS 0** | **PRIORITY 147/228**

ABOUT THIS QUESTION

Topic: Core 90 - Binary search

Optimal answer from: written and tested here for this exact question

LeetCode match: LC 1891 Cutting Ribbons

Frequency: Single report | Last asked: 2026-08-16 | Roles: SWE

Original: https://www.1point3acres.com/interview/problems/company/google/cutting-ribbons-max-equal-length

QUESTION

LC 1891 Cutting Ribbons: given wood lengths and K, maximize the equal piece length that yields at least K pieces. Follow-ups cover the search bound, floating-point lengths, and why complexity depends on the value range rather than the number of elements.SWEarraybinary-searchcomplexity-analysismedium FrequencySingle reportLast asked2026-08-16Stageonsite-coding

APPROACH

Implement the integer version from memory and prove the monotonic feasibility predicate.
Rework it with floating-point lengths and explain termination under both fixed-iteration and epsilon-based policies.
Practice stating the bound and complexity in terms of the numeric value domain without conflating it with input size.

INTERVIEW-DAY PLAN

CLARIFY FIRST

Ask whether piece lengths must be integers, what to return if even length 1 fails (0), and the sizes of the array and k.

BRUTE FORCE TO SAY OUT LOUD

Try every length from the maximum down to 1 and count pieces. O(n * max).

OPTIMAL IDEA

Feasibility is monotone: if you can cut k pieces of length L you can for any smaller length. Binary search L over [1, max]: count = sum(r // L), move right if count >= k. O(n log max). A tighter upper bound is min(max, sum // k).

DRY-RUN THESE CASES

k larger than the total length (0), one ribbon, all equal ribbons, k = 1 (answer is the max ribbon).

LIKELY FOLLOW-UPS

INTERVIEW-DAY PLAN

Real-valued lengths (fixed number of halvings, not an epsilon loop), why complexity depends on the value range, or an unlimited number of cuts.

PITFALLS

Overflow when summing. Searching from 0 and dividing by zero.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

'Largest length such that at least K pieces fit' is a maximisation with a yes/no check. Larger lengths yield fewer pieces, so the check is monotone and you can binary search the answer. The check itself is one pass: sum of ribbon // length.

Basis: LeetCode 1891, Cutting Ribbons.

BRUTE FORCE

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
def brute(ribbons, k):
    for L in range(max(ribbons), 0, -1):
        pieces = sum(r // L for r in ribbons)
        if pieces >= k:
            return L
    return 0
```

TIME	SPACE
O(n * max)	O(1)

WHY IT IS SLOW

Tries up to max(ribbon) lengths, each costing O(n); with ribbons up to 10^9 that is a billion probes. The check is monotone, so binary search needs only log2(max) probes.

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Binary search the answer (integer lengths)

TIME	SPACE
O(n log(max length))	O(1)

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

FOLLOW-UP 1 Why does the running time depend on the value range and not just on the number of ribbons?

Each probe costs O(n), and the number of probes is log2(max length) for the integer version. A huge length like 10^9 needs about 30 probes while 10 needs 4, even with the same n. For real numbers the probe count is set by the precision you promise, e.g. log2(max / epsilon).

FOLLOW-UP 2 What if the candidate length is given to you?

Then it is just the feasibility check: sum(r // L for r in ribbons) >= k, in O(n). The binary search exists only to find the best L; the check is the same function you reuse inside it.

FOLLOW-UP 3 What is a good upper bound for the search?

min(max(ribbons), sum(ribbons) // k). If the total length divided by k is smaller than the longest ribbon, no piece longer than that can ever give k pieces, which shrinks the range a little and avoids wasted probes. **Cost:** each probe is O(n); the tighter bound removes only a few of the log2(max) probes, so the total stays O(n log max).

FOLLOW-UP 4 Give the search a tighter upper bound.

No piece can be longer than the longest ribbon, and K pieces of length L need K * L total length, so L <= sum // K. Starting hi at min(max(ribbons), sum // K) saves a few probes and also returns 0 immediately when sum < K.

FULL INTERVIEW CODE · base question + every follow-up

One program for the whole question: the base answer and every follow-up above, built from small helper functions, with a comment above each step. Type it top to bottom in the interview; the demo at the bottom runs it.

```
# MAIN QUESTION: Cutting Ribbons (LC 1891)
#
# LC 1891 Cutting Ribbons: given wood lengths and K,
# maximize the equal piece length that yields at least K
# pieces. Follow-ups cover the search bound, floating-
# point lengths, and why complexity depends on the value
# range rather than the number of elements.
#
# FOLLOW-UPS (answered below, in this order):
# 1. Why does the running time depend on the value range
# and not just on the number of ribbons?
# 2. What if the candidate length is given to you?
# 3. What is a good upper bound for the search?
# 4. Give the search a tighter upper bound.
#
# INTERVIEW NOTES
# 'Largest length such that at least K pieces fit' is a
# maximisation with a yes/no check. Larger lengths yield
# fewer pieces, so the check is monotone and you can
# binary search the answer. The check itself is one pass:
# sum of ribbon // length.
#
# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Try every length from the
# longest ribbon down
# For each length L from the maximum ribbon down to 1
# count the pieces and return the first L that gives at
# least K. Correct, but with ribbons up to 10^9 it would
# try a billion lengths. Time O(n * max). Space O(1).


# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Try every length from the
# longest ribbon down | time O(n * max)
def max_length_brute(ribbons, k):
    for L in range(max(ribbons), 0, -1):
        if sum(r // L for r in ribbons) >= k:
            return L
    return 0
```

```
# HELPERS for the base question
def pieces(ribbons, length):
    # how many pieces of this length can we cut?
    return sum(r // length for r in ribbons)
```

```
# FOLLOW-UP 4: Give the search a tighter upper bound.
# Answer: No piece can be longer than the longest ribbon,
# and K pieces of length L need K * L total length, so L
# <= sum // K. Starting hi at min(max(ribbons), sum // K)
# saves a few probes and also returns 0 immediately when
# sum < K.
# NEEDED BY THE BASE QUESTION: it is also the answer to
# the follow-up below
def upper_bound(ribbons, k):
    # no piece is longer than the longest ribbon, and
    # k pieces of length L need k * L total length
    return min(max(ribbons), sum(ribbons) // k)


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): Binary search the answer
# (integer lengths)
# Idea: If you can cut k pieces of length L you can cut k
# pieces of any shorter length, so feasibility is
# monotone.
def max_length(ribbons, k):
    # the best whole-number length (0 if impossible)
    lo, hi, best = 1, upper_bound(ribbons, k), 0
    while lo <= hi:
        mid = (lo + hi) // 2
        if pieces(ribbons, mid) >= k:
            # mid works: remember it and try longer
            best, lo = mid, mid + 1
        else:
            hi = mid - 1
    return best


# VARIANT: fractional lengths
def max_length_float(ribbons, k, rounds=50):
    # lengths may be fractions: fixed rounds of halving
    lo, hi = 0.0, float(max(ribbons))
    for _ in range(rounds):
        mid = (lo + hi) / 2
        # enough pieces: the answer is at least mid
        if sum(int(r // mid) for r in ribbons) >= k:
            lo = mid
        else:
            hi = mid
    return lo
```

```
if __name__ == "__main__":
    assert max_length([9, 7, 5], 3) == 5
    assert max_length([7, 5, 9], 4) == 4
    # not enough total length: no pieces at all
    assert max_length([1, 2], 10) == 0
    # the check alone, when the length is given
    assert pieces([9, 7, 5], 5) == 3
    assert upper_bound([9, 7, 5], 3) == 7
    # fractional lengths: 3 pieces from one ribbon of 1
    assert abs(max_length_float([1], 3) - 1 / 3) < 1e-9
    assert max_length_float([1], 0 + 2) > 0.49
```

NOTES FROM CANDIDATES

The interviewer allowed the candidate to abandon an initial greedy/sorting direction, then unlocked the problem with one question: what changes if a candidate length is supplied?
Expect the follow-ups, not the base implementation, to consume most of the round.
For the integer version, initialize the best answer to 0, search only positive candidate lengths, and return 0 when even length 1 cannot produce K pieces. The feasibility predicate is monotone: once a length is infeasible, every larger length is also infeasible.

PREPARATION

Implement the integer version from memory and prove the monotonic feasibility predicate.
Rework it with floating-point lengths and explain termination under both fixed-iteration and epsilon-based policies.
Practice stating the bound and complexity in terms of the numeric value domain without conflating it with input size.

STUDY PATH: question 60 of 167 (Core 90)

Priority score 4.14 | Binary search | asked 127 days ago | frequency Single report

MEDIUM | 1Point3Acres | phone-screen | 2 of 4

★ TOP 75: rank 72 in the Medium and Hard priority list

★ First Bad Version with Parallel Search Follow-up

ASKED 2026-06-15 | 127 DAYS AGO | LAST 6 MONTHS

STUDY: TYPE | **ALL TIME 41.1** | **30 DAYS 33** | **PRIORITY 47/228**

ABOUT THIS QUESTION

Topic: Core 90 - Binary search

Optimal answer from: written and tested here for this exact question

This question has several parts, so each part has its own answer below.

Related in your app (a neighbouring problem, not this exact question): LeetCode #278 First Bad Version

LeetCode match: LC 278 First Bad Version

Frequency: Single report | Last asked: 2026-06-15 | Roles: SWE

Original: https://www.1point3acres.com/interview/problems/company/google/first-bad-version-parallel-search

QUESTION

Phone-screen R1 coding round. The base problem is the standard first-bad-version monotonic search — given an `isBadVersion(v)` oracle over versions `1..n`, find the first bad version with a single binary search. The graded follow-up requires parallelizing the search: partition the range into buckets and search them concurrently (bucket + binary search), with working code expected.SWEbinary-searchparallelismconcurrencymediumFrequencySingle reportLast asked2026-06-15Stagephone-screen

APPROACH

Write the single-threaded binary search first and verify it on small n.
Then implement the bucketed parallel version with real concurrency primitives (Python concurrent.futures.ThreadPoolExecutor, or Java ExecutorService / CompletableFuture): split [1, n] into k buckets, probe the k boundaries concurrently, pick the bucket where the predicate flips, and binary-search within it. Practice getting this to compile and run in under 20 minutes.

INTERVIEW-DAY PLAN

CLARIFY FIRST

Ask what the oracle is (isBadVersion is monotone), what concurrency primitive to use (ThreadPoolExecutor, Java's ExecutorService), and which metric matters: wall-clock time or total calls.

BRUTE FORCE TO SAY OUT LOUD

Check every version from 1. O(n) calls.

INTERVIEW-DAY PLAN

OPTIMAL IDEA

Base: binary search, O(log n) calls. Parallel: each round fires up to k probes concurrently at evenly spaced points, finds the first probe that is bad, and narrows the interval to the gap between it and the previous probe. Each round shrinks the interval by k + 1, so there are about log base (k + 1) of n sequential rounds. Use a thread pool and map the probes in one call.

DRY-RUN THESE CASES

n = 1, the first version bad, the last version bad, n smaller than the number of workers.

LIKELY FOLLOW-UPS

Rate limiting, retries when a probe fails, and caching results.

PITFALLS

Mutating shared state from threads. Assuming more threads always means fewer total calls (they increase it).

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

'First bad version' is a boundary in a sorted yes/no sequence, which is binary search. The parallel part is a different trade: instead of one probe per round, send several probes in the same round and keep the gap that contains the boundary. Fewer rounds, more total calls.

Basis: LeetCode 278, First Bad Version, plus a concurrent k-ary search follow-up.

BRUTE FORCE

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
def brute(n):
    for v in range(1, n + 1):
        if is_bad_version(v):
            return v
```

TIME	SPACE
O(n)	O(1)
calls	

WHY IT IS SLOW

One call per version, O(n) calls; with a billion versions and a slow check that is far too many. The check is monotone, so binary search needs only log2(n) calls, and probing several points in parallel needs fewer rounds.

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Base problem: binary search

TIME	SPACE
O(log n)	O(1)
calls	

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Parallel: probe k points at once, then recurse into the bucket that flips

TIME	SPACE
O(log_{k+1} n) rounds	O(k)

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

FOLLOW-UP 1 What does parallelism buy you, and what does it cost?

It cuts the number of sequential rounds from log2(n) to log_{k+1}(n), so wall-clock time drops when each probe has high latency. It increases total probes (about k per round instead of 1), so it costs more calls and money. Say which metric you are optimizing before choosing k.

FOLLOW-UP 2 What if the oracle is rate limited or can fail?

Cap the pool size to the rate limit, retry transient failures with backoff (probes are idempotent), and never advance the interval from a probe that errored. Cache results by version so a retry or a later round never repeats a call.

FOLLOW-UP 3 Count how many rounds each approach needs.

Single binary search: log2(n) rounds of one probe each. k workers: about log base (k + 1) of n rounds with k probes each. For n = 10^9, one probe per round needs 30 rounds, while 7 probes per round need 10.

FOLLOW-UP 4 Show how many rounds and calls the parallel search uses.

With k workers each round shrinks the interval by about k + 1, so the number of sequential rounds is about log base (k + 1) of n and the total calls at most k times that. For n = 10^6 and 7 workers that is about 7 rounds and 49 calls, against 20 rounds and 20 calls for the sequential search: fewer rounds, more calls.

FULL INTERVIEW CODE · base question + every follow-up

One program for the whole question: the base answer and every follow-up above, built from small helper functions, with a comment above each step. Type it top to bottom in the interview; the demo at the bottom runs it.

```
# MAIN QUESTION: First Bad Version with Parallel Search
# Follow-up
#
# Phone-screen R1 coding round. The base problem is the
# standard first-bad-version monotonic search — given an
# isBadVersion(v) oracle over versions 1..n, find the
# first bad version with a single binary search. The
# graded follow-up requires parallelizing the search:
# partition the range into buckets and search them
# concurrently (bucket + binary search), with working code
# expected.
#
# FOLLOW-UPS (answered below, in this order):
# 1. What does parallelism buy you, and what does it cost?
# 2. What if the oracle is rate limited or can fail?
# 3. Count how many rounds each approach needs.
# 4. Show how many rounds and calls the parallel search
# uses.
#
# INTERVIEW NOTES
# 'First bad version' is a boundary in a sorted yes/no
# sequence, which is binary search. The parallel part is a
# different trade: instead of one probe per round, send
# several probes in the same round and keep the gap that
# contains the boundary. Fewer rounds, more total calls.
#
# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Check versions one by one
# Call isBadVersion for 1, 2, 3, ... and stop at the first
# bad one. Obviously correct and the oracle; with a
# billion versions and a slow check it is far too many
# calls. Time O(n) calls. Space O(1).


from concurrent.futures import ThreadPoolExecutor
from threading import Lock


# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Check versions one by one |
# time O(n) calls
def first_bad_linear(n, is_bad):
    return next(v for v in range(1, n + 1) if is_bad(v))


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): problem: binary search
# Idea: isBad is monotone (all good, then all bad), so
# keep the invariant 'the first bad version is in [lo,
# hi]' and halve the interval. Use lo + (hi - lo) // 2 in
# languages with fixed-width integers.
def first_bad_version(n, is_bad):
    # the base question: binary search on versions 1..n
    lo, hi = 1, n
    while lo < hi:
        mid = lo + (hi - lo) // 2
        if is_bad(mid):
            # the first bad version is mid or earlier
            hi = mid
        else:
            lo = mid + 1
    return lo


# PARALLEL SEARCH helper
def probe_points(lo, hi, workers):
    # evenly spaced versions inside [lo, hi - 1]
    step = max(1, (hi - lo + 1) // (workers + 1))
    pts = {min(hi - 1, lo + step * (i + 1) - 1)
           for i in range(workers)}
    return sorted(pts)


# FOLLOW-UP 1: What does parallelism buy you, and what
# does it cost?
# Answer: It cuts the number of sequential rounds from
# log2(n) to log_{k+1}(n), so wall-clock time drops when
# each probe has high latency. It increases total probes
# (about k per round instead of 1), so it costs more calls
# and money.
# FOLLOW-UP 3: Count how many rounds each approach needs.
# Answer: Single binary search: log2(n) rounds of one
# probe each. k workers: about log base (k + 1) of n
# rounds with k probes each. For n = 10^9, one probe per
```

```
# round needs 30 rounds, while 7 probes per round need 10.
# FOLLOW-UP 4: Show how many rounds and calls the parallel
# search uses.
# Answer: With k workers each round shrinks the interval
# by about k + 1, so the number of sequential rounds is
# about log base (k + 1) of n and the total calls at most
# k times that.
def first_bad_parallel(n, is_bad, workers=4):
    # invariant: the answer is in [lo, hi]
```

```
    lo, hi, cache, rounds = 1, n, {}, 0
    with ThreadPoolExecutor(workers) as pool:
        while lo < hi:
            points = probe_points(lo, hi, workers)
            # ask the oracle about new points at the same
            # time
            fresh = [p for p in points if p not in cache]
            answers = pool.map(is_bad, fresh)
            for p, bad in zip(fresh, answers):
                cache[p] = bad
            rounds += 1
            bad_points = [p for p in points if cache[p]]
            if not bad_points:
                # every probe was good: answer is after
                # them
                lo = points[-1] + 1
            else:
                first = bad_points[0]
                # the answer sits between the last good
                # probe before it and the first bad one
                before = [p for p in points if p < first]
                if before:
                    lo = before[-1] + 1
                hi = first
    return lo, rounds, len(cache)


if __name__ == "__main__":
    calls, lock = [], Lock()

    def oracle(first_bad):
        def is_bad(v):
            with lock:
                calls.append(v)
            return v >= first_bad
        return is_bad

    cases = ((1, 1), (10, 1), (10, 10), (1000, 637))
    for n, bad in cases:
        assert first_bad_version(n, oracle(bad)) == bad
        ans, rounds, used = first_bad_parallel(
            n, oracle(bad), workers=4)
        assert ans == bad
    # fewer rounds than the 20 of a plain binary search
    ans, rounds, used = first_bad_parallel(
```

```
        10 ** 6, oracle(123456), workers=7)
    assert ans == 123456 and rounds < 20
    assert used <= 7 * rounds
```

NOTES FROM CANDIDATES

The base is trivial; budget your time for the parallel follow-up and aim to get a complete, compiling version through even if it has minor bugs — finishing the parallel version is what passes this round.

Be explicit about what the parallel design optimizes: wall-clock latency (fire many isBadVersion probes at once) versus total number of calls. Splitting into k buckets and probing each boundary concurrently localizes the transition in one parallel round, then a binary search finishes it.

Common bugs: off-by-one when mapping a bucket index back to an absolute version range; the transition sitting exactly on a bucket boundary; integer overflow in mid if you write (lo + hi) / 2 instead of lo + (hi - lo) // 2.

PREPARATION

Write the single-threaded binary search first and verify it on small n.

Then implement the bucketed parallel version with real concurrency primitives (Python concurrent.futures.ThreadPoolExecutor, or Java ExecutorService / CompletableFuture): split [1, n] into k buckets, probe the k boundaries concurrently, pick the bucket where the predicate flips, and binary-search within it. Practice getting this to compile and run in under 20 minutes.

STUDY PATH: question 61 of 167 (Core 90)

Priority score 3.97 | Binary search | asked 287 days ago

MEDIUM | PracHub | Technical Screen | 3 of 4

★ TOP 75: rank 2 in the Medium and Hard priority list

★ Find median of merged RLE arrays

POSTED 2026-01-06 | 287 DAYS AGO | OLDER

STUDY: TYPE | ALL TIME 74.2 | 30 DAYS 61 | PRIORITY 5/228

ABOUT THIS QUESTION

Topic: Core 90 - Binary search

Optimal answer from: the interview site's own solution

Related in your app (a neighbouring problem, not this exact question): LeetCode #4 Median of Two Sorted Arrays

LeetCode match: LC 4 Median of Two Sorted Arrays (RLE variant) (inferred from overview)

Posted on PracHub: 2026-01-06 (updated 2026-06-27)

Original: https://prachub.com/coding-questions/find-median-of-merged-rle-arrays

QUESTION

Overview: The question evaluates understanding of run-length encoding, order-statistics (median) computation, and efficient merging of frequency-annotated sequences, emphasizing handling large frequencies without explicit decompression.

APPROACH

Total length = sum of run counts; walk both run lists merged by value accumulating counts until the median index(es) are covered. Or binary search on value with counts.

INTERVIEW-DAY PLAN

CLARIFY FIRST

Ask whether each array is sorted by value, how large counts can be (so decompression is impossible), and what to return for an even total (average of the two middle values).

BRUTE FORCE TO SAY OUT LOUD

Decompress both arrays, merge, take the middle. O(total count) memory, which counts can make huge.

OPTIMAL IDEA

Let N be the sum of all counts and the median positions be (N - 1) // 2 and N // 2. Merge the two run lists by value with two pointers (like the merge step of merge sort), accumulating counts until the running total passes each median position, and read the value there. O(r1 + r2) with no decompression. Alternative: binary search on the value, counting how many elements are at most that value in each array.

DRY-RUN THESE CASES

A single run, an even total, the median falling exactly on a run boundary, both arrays with the same values, an empty array.

LIKELY FOLLOW-UPS

INTERVIEW-DAY PLAN

K arrays (heap merge), or arrays not sorted by value.

PITFALLS

Treating counts as lengths of different arrays instead of merging by value. Off-by-one at a run boundary.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Counts can be huge, so never expand a run. You only need the elements at ranks (N - 1) // 2 and N // 2 in the merged order. Merge the two run lists by value, counting how many elements you have passed, and read the value when the count reaches each rank.

Basis: Written; LeetCode 4 with run-length encoded inputs. Assumed input: two lists of (value, count) runs, each sorted by value; the median of the merged multiset (average of the two middle values for an even total).

BRUTE FORCE

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
def brute(runs_a, runs_b):
    dense = []
    for value, count in runs_a + runs_b:
        dense += [value] * count
    dense.sort()
    n = len(dense)
    if n % 2:
        return dense[n // 2]
    mid = n // 2
    return (dense[mid - 1] + dense[mid]) / 2
```

TIME	SPACE
O(total count)	O(total count)

WHY IT IS SLOW

Needs time and memory proportional to the total count, which can be 10^9 or more. Walking the two run lists in value order and counting up to the middle rank costs only the number of runs.

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Merge the runs and walk to the two middle ranks

TIME	SPACE
O(r1 + r2)	O(1)

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

FOLLOW-UP 1 K arrays instead of two.

Merge all runs by value (heap of K heads, or sort the combined run list if memory allows) and walk to the two middle ranks. O(R log K) with a heap, R the total number of runs.

FOLLOW-UP 2 The arrays are huge and sorted, and you want O(log) time.

Binary search on the value: for a candidate value count how many elements are at most it in each array (binary search on prefix sums of counts) and find the smallest value with rank above the middle. O(log(range) * log(runs)).

FOLLOW-UP 3 Runs are not sorted by value.

Sort the runs by value first, O(R log R), then use the same walk.

FULL INTERVIEW CODE · base question + every follow-up

One program for the whole question: the base answer and every follow-up above, built from small helper functions, with a comment above each step. Type it top to bottom in the interview; the demo at the bottom runs it.

```
# MAIN QUESTION: Find median of merged RLE arrays
#
# The question evaluates understanding of run-length
# encoding, order-statistics (median) computation, and
# efficient merging of frequency-annotated sequences,
# emphasizing handling large frequencies without explicit
# decompression.
#
# FOLLOW-UPS (answered below, in this order):
# 1. K arrays instead of two.
# 2. The arrays are huge and sorted, and you want O(log)
# time.
# 3. Runs are not sorted by value.
#
# INTERVIEW NOTES
# Counts can be huge, so never expand a run. You only need
# the elements at ranks (N - 1) // 2 and N // 2 in the
# merged order. Merge the two run lists by value, counting
# how many elements you have passed, and read the value
# when the count reaches each rank.
#
# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Expand both arrays, merge
# and take the middle
# Decompress each run into repeated values, merge, and
# read the middle. Correct, and the oracle; counts like
# 10^9 make the expansion impossible. Time O(total count).
# Space O(total count).


import heapq
from bisect import bisect_right
from itertools import accumulate


# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Expand both arrays, merge
# and take the middle | time O(total count)
def median_rle_expand(a, b):
    data = sorted(
        [v for v, c in a for _ in range(c)]
        + [v for v, c in b for _ in range(c)]
    )
    n = len(data)
    return (
        data[n // 2]
        if n % 2
        else (data[n // 2 - 1] + data[n // 2]) / 2
    )
```

```
# HELPERS for the base question
def kth_smallest(runs_a, runs_b, k):
    # zero-based rank in the merged order, walking the
    # runs
    # of two sorted run-length lists; nothing is expanded
    i = j = seen = 0
    while True:
        take_a = j >= len(runs_b)
        if not take_a and i < len(runs_a):
            take_a = runs_a[i][0] <= runs_b[j][0]
        value, count = runs_a[i] if take_a else runs_b[j]
        seen += count
        if seen > k:
            return value
        if take_a:
            i += 1
        else:
            j += 1


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): Merge the runs and walk to the
# two middle ranks
# Idea: Let N be the sum of all counts.
def median_rle(a, b):
    # a and b: [(value, count)] sorted by value
    total = sum(c for _, c in a) + sum(c for _, c in b)
    if total % 2:
        return kth_smallest(a, b, total // 2)
    low = kth_smallest(a, b, total // 2 - 1)
    high = kth_smallest(a, b, total // 2)
    return (low + high) / 2


# FOLLOW-UP 1: K arrays instead of two.
# Answer: Merge all runs by value (heap of K heads, or
# sort the combined run list if memory allows) and walk to
# the two middle ranks. O(R log K) with a heap, R the
# total number of runs.
def median_k_arrays(arrays):
    # K arrays: merge the run lists by value, then walk to
    # the
    # middle ranks
    runs = list(heapq.merge(*arrays))
    total = sum(c for _, c in runs)

    def kth(k):
        seen = 0
        for value, count in runs:
            seen += count
            if seen > k:
                return value

    if total % 2:
        return kth(total // 2)
    return (kth(total // 2 - 1) + kth(total // 2)) / 2


# FOLLOW-UP 2: The arrays are huge and sorted, and you
# want O(log) time.
# Answer: Binary search on the value: for a candidate
# value count how many elements are at most it in each
# array (binary search on prefix sums of counts) and find
# the smallest value with rank above the middle.
# O(log(range) * log(runs)).
def median_by_value(arrays):
    # sorted arrays, whole-number values: binary search
    # the
    # value; count_at_most uses prefix sums of the counts
    prefixes = []
    for runs in arrays:
        values = [v for v, _ in runs]
```

```
        sums = list(accumulate(c for _, c in runs))
        prefixes.append((values, sums))

    def count_at_most(x):
        total = 0
        for values, sums in prefixes:
            i = bisect_right(values, x)
            total += sums[i - 1] if i else 0
        return total

    n = count_at_most(10 ** 18)

    def kth(k):
        lo, hi = -(10 ** 18), 10 ** 18
        while lo < hi:
```

```
            mid = (lo + hi) // 2
            # smallest value with more than k elements <=
            # it
            if count_at_most(mid) > k:
                hi = mid
            else:
                lo = mid + 1
        return lo

    if n % 2:
        return kth(n // 2)
    return (kth(n // 2 - 1) + kth(n // 2)) / 2


if __name__ == "__main__":
    a = [(1, 3), (4, 1)]
    b = [(2, 2), (5, 2)]
    # merged: 1 1 1 2 2 4 5 5 -> middle two are 2 and 2
    assert median_rle(a, b) == 2
    assert median_k_arrays([a, b]) == 2
    assert median_by_value([a, b]) == 2
    # an odd total: 1, 7, 7, 7, 7, 7 plus one more 7
    assert median_rle([(7, 6)], [(1, 1)]) == 7
    # huge counts are never expanded
    big = [(1, 10 ** 12)]
    assert median_rle(big, [(3, 10 ** 12)]) == 2
    c = [(0, 1), (10, 1)]
    three = [a, b, c]
    by_merge = median_k_arrays(three)
    assert by_merge == median_by_value(three)
```

FUNCTION AND TEST CASES

Sample call

```
solution([(1, 2), (5, 1)], [(2, 3)])
```

Test cases

Input	Expected
`([(1, 2), (5, 1)], [(2, 3)])`	`2.0`
`([(1, 1)], [(2, 1)])`	`1.5`

STUDY PATH: question 62 of 167 (Core 90)

Priority score 3.61 | Binary search | asked 631 days ago

MEDIUM | PracHub | Technical Screen | 4 of 4

★ TOP 75: rank 12 in the Medium and Hard priority list

★ Solve Banana Speed and Interval Merge

POSTED 2025-01-27 | 631 DAYS AGO | OLDER

STUDY: TYPE | ALL TIME 65.2 | 30 DAYS 41.1 | PRIORITY 10/228

ABOUT THIS QUESTION

Topic: Core 90 - Binary search

Optimal answer from: written and tested here for this exact question

This question has several parts, so each part has its own answer below.

Related in your app (a neighbouring problem, not this exact question): LeetCode #875 Koko Eating Bananas, LeetCode #56 Merge Intervals

LeetCode match: LC 875 Koko Eating Bananas + LC 56 Merge Intervals

Posted on PracHub: 2025-01-27 (updated 2026-06-26)

Original: https://prachub.com/coding-questions/solve-banana-speed-and-interval-merge

QUESTION

During two technical phone screens for a new graduate software engineering role, the candidate was asked to solve two coding problems: minimum eating speed and merging overlapping intervals.

Constraints & Assumptions

- Provide clear algorithms, correctness reasoning, complexity, and edge cases.
- For minimum eating speed, each hour can be spent on only one pile.
- For interval merging, intervals overlap when the next start is less than or equal to the current merged end.
- Use sorted or binary-search approaches where appropriate.

Clarifying Questions

to Ask - Are **`piles`** and **h** always positive?

- Is **h** at least the number of piles?
- Are interval endpoints inclusive?
- Can intervals be empty or unsorted?

Part 1

- Minimum Eating Speed Given **`piles`** and **h**, return the minimum integer speed **k** such that all piles can be eaten within **h** hours.

What This Part Should Cover

- Binary search on answer from 1 to **`max(piles)`**.
- Feasibility function using sum of **`ceil(pile / k)`**.
- Why feasibility is monotonic.
- Complexity and edge cases.

Part 2

QUESTION

- Merge Overlapping Intervals Given intervals **`[start, end]`**, merge all overlapping intervals and return non-overlapping intervals sorted by start.

What This Part Should Cover

- Sort by start.
- Maintain current merged interval.
- Extend on overlap, otherwise append and start a new interval.
- Complexity and edge cases.

What a Strong

Answer Covers - Recognizes monotonic binary search for eating speed.

- Uses integer-safe ceiling division.
- Correctly defines interval overlap.
- Gives clean code and complexity for both problems.

Follow-up Questions

- How would you avoid floating-point division in the banana problem?
- What if **h** is smaller than the number of piles?
- How do you merge touching intervals like **`[1,3]`** and **`[3,5]`**?
- How would you handle streaming intervals?Minimum Eating Speed (Koko Eating Bananas)Koko loves to eat bananas. There are **n** piles of bananas; the i-th pile has **`piles[i]`** bananas. The guards will return in **h** hours. Koko can decide her constant bananas-per-hour eating speed **k**. Each hour she chooses one pile and eats **k** bananas from it. If that pile has fewer than **k** bananas, she eats all of them and does not eat more during that hour. An hour is spent on only one pile. Return the minimum integer speed **k** such that she can finish all the bananas within **h** hours. Example:
- **`piles = [3, 6, 7, 11]`**, **`h = 8`** -> **`4`**
- **`piles = [30, 11, 23, 4, 20]`**, **`h = 5`** -> **`30`**
- **`piles = [30, 11, 23, 4, 20]`**, **`h = 6`** -> **`23`**
  Constraints: **`1 <= piles.length <= h`**, **`1 <= piles[i] <= 10^9`**.

Constraints

1 <= piles.length <= h1 <= piles[i] <= 10^9h can be as large as 10^9

EXAMPLES

```
Input: ([3, 6, 7, 11], 8)
Expected Output: 4
Explanation: At k=4:
    ceil(3/4)+ceil(6/4)+ceil(7/4)+ceil(11/4) =
    1+2+2+3 = 8 hours. k=3 needs 1+2+3+4 = 10 > 8, so
    4 is minimal.
Input: ([30, 11, 23, 4, 20], 5)
Expected Output: 30
```

Explanation: With exactly 5 piles and 5 hours, each pile must be eaten in one hour, so k must be at least max(piles) = 30.

QUESTION

Hints

If speed k finishes in time, any larger speed also finishes in time. This monotonicity lets you binary search on the answer.The answer lies in [1, max(piles)]: speed 1 is the slowest, and max(piles) finishes every pile in at most one hour.Hours needed at speed k is sum of ceil(pile / k). Use integer-safe ceiling: (pile + k - 1) // k to avoid floating point.Merge Overlapping IntervalsGiven an array of intervals where **`intervals[i] = [start_i, end_i]`**, merge all overlapping intervals and return an array of the non-overlapping intervals that cover all the intervals in the input, sorted by start. Two intervals overlap when the next start is less than or equal to the current merged end

APPROACH

Binary search the speed with ceil(pile/speed) sum <= h; sort intervals by start and merge overlaps in one pass.

INTERVIEW-DAY PLAN

CLARIFY FIRST

Bananas: piles and h are positive, h is at least the number of piles (otherwise impossible), one pile per hour, and an hour finishes at most one pile. Intervals: overlap includes touching (next start at most the current end).

BRUTE FORCE TO SAY OUT LOUD

Bananas: try every speed from 1 up. Intervals: compare every pair.

OPTIMAL IDEA

Bananas (LeetCode 875): the time function is monotone in the speed, so binary search the smallest speed in [1, max(piles)] with sum(ceil(p / s)) <= h. O(n log max). Intervals: sort by start and sweep, merging while the next start is at most the current end. O(n log n).

DRY-RUN THESE CASES

Bananas: h equal to the pile count (speed is the maximum), a single pile, large piles (overflow). Intervals: touching, nested, unsorted, one interval.

LIKELY FOLLOW-UPS

Bananas with a variable h or a floating-point speed. Intervals: insert one interval or count the merged result.

PITFALLS

Using floor instead of ceil. Merging with strict less-than.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Bananas: the time needed is non-increasing in the speed, so the smallest speed that finishes in h hours can be found by binary search over speeds, with a simple sum of ceil(pile / speed) as the check. Intervals: sort by start and sweep with one 'current' interval; the sort guarantees nothing earlier can still overlap.

HOW TO THINK ABOUT IT

Basis: LeetCode 875 (Koko Eating Bananas; one pile per hour, h at least the number of piles) and LeetCode 56 (Merge Intervals; overlapping when the next start is at most the current end).

BRUTE FORCE · Bananas: try every speed upward

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
def brute(piles, h):
    for speed in range(1, max(piles) + 1):
        hours = 0
        for p in piles:
            hours += ceil(p / speed)
        if hours <= h:
            return speed
```

TIME	SPACE
O(max * n)	O(1)

WHY IT IS SLOW

Up to max(piles) speeds, each costing O(n); piles can be 10^9. Hours are non-increasing in the speed, so binary search over speeds is O(n log max).

BRUTE FORCE · Intervals: merge any overlapping pair until none is left

BRUTE FORCE · PSEUDO-CODE

```
def merge(intervals):
    intervals = list(intervals)
    merged = True
    while merged:
        merged = False
        for a, b in combinations(intervals, 2):
            if overlaps(a, b):
                intervals.remove(a)
                intervals.remove(b)
                intervals.append(union(a, b))
                merged = True
                break
    return sorted(intervals)
```

TIME	SPACE
O(n^2)	O(n)

WHY IT IS SLOW

Each pass compares all pairs, O(n^2), and several passes may be needed. Sorting by start and sweeping once is O(n log n).

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Bananas: binary search the speed

TIME	SPACE
O(n log max)	O(1)

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

OPTIMAL SOLUTION · Intervals: sort and sweep

TIME	SPACE
O(n log n)	O(n)

Code: see FULL INTERVIEW CODE below (the optimal solution is its main function).

FOLLOW-UP 1 Bananas: h varies per query, or the piles change.

The check is independent of the search; for many queries keep the piles sorted with prefix sums so the hours needed at speed s can be computed in O(log n) per distinct pile size.

FOLLOW-UP 2 Intervals: insert one new interval into an already merged list (LeetCode 57).

Copy intervals ending before the new one, merge the ones that overlap it, then copy the rest. O(n), no sort needed.

FOLLOW-UP 3 Bananas: the guards come back in fewer hours than piles.

Then no speed works (an hour can finish at most one pile): check h >= len(piles) first and return -1 otherwise.

FULL INTERVIEW CODE · base question + every follow-up

One program for the whole question: the base answer and every follow-up above, built from small helper functions, with a comment above each step. Type it top to bottom in the interview; the demo at the bottom runs it.

```
# MAIN QUESTION: Solve Banana Speed and Interval Merge
#
# During two technical phone screens for a new graduate
# software engineering role, the candidate was asked to
# solve two coding problems: minimum eating speed and
# merging overlapping intervals. ### Constraints &
# Assumptions - Provide clear algorithms, correctness
# reasoning, complexity, and edge cases. - For minimum
# eating speed, each hour can be spent on only one pile. -
# For interval merging, intervals overlap when the next
# start is less than or equal to the current merged end. -
# Use sorted or binary-search approaches where
# appropriate. ### Clarifying Questions to Ask - Are piles
# and h always positive? - Is h at least the number of
# piles? - Are interval endpoints inclusive? - Can
# intervals be empty or unsorted? ### Part 1 - Minimum
# Eating Speed Given piles and h, return the minimum
# integer speed k such that all piles can be eaten within
# h hours.
#
# FOLLOW-UPS (answered below, in this order):
# 1. Bananas: h varies per query, or the piles change.
# 2. Intervals: insert one new interval into an already
# merged list (LeetCode 57).
# 3. Bananas: the guards come back in fewer hours than
# piles.
#
# INTERVIEW NOTES
# Bananas: the time needed is non-increasing in the speed,
# so the smallest speed that finishes in h hours can be
# found by binary search over speeds, with a simple sum of
# ceil(pile / speed) as the check. Intervals: sort by
# start and sweep with one 'current' interval; the sort
# guarantees nothing earlier can still overlap.
#
# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Bananas: try every speed
# upward
# For speed 1, 2, 3, ... compute the hours needed and
# return the first speed that fits in h. Correct and the
# oracle; the speed can be 10^9. Time O(max * n). Space
# O(1).


# BRUTE FORCE (say it first): Bananas: try every speed
# upward | time O(max * n)
```

```
def banana_speed_linear(piles, h):
    for speed in range(1, max(piles) + 1):
        if sum(-(-p // speed) for p in piles) <= h:
            return speed


# HELPERS for the base question
def hours_needed(piles, speed):
    # each hour she works on ONE pile, so every pile
    # rounds up
    return sum(-(-p // speed) for p in piles)


# BASE QUESTION (optimal): Bananas: binary search the
# speed
# Idea: Hours needed are non-increasing in the speed, so
# keep lo = 1 and hi = max(piles) and halve: if speed mid
# finishes within h, try slower, otherwise faster. Use
# ceiling division (an hour finishes at most one pile).
def min_eating_speed(piles, h):
    # fewer hours than piles can never work
    if h < len(piles):
        return -1
    lo, hi = 1, max(piles)
    # more speed never takes more hours: binary search
    while lo < hi:
        mid = (lo + hi) // 2
        if hours_needed(piles, mid) <= h:
            hi = mid
        else:
            lo = mid + 1
    return lo


# PART 2: merge intervals
def merge_intervals(intervals):
    out = []
    for s, e in sorted(intervals):
        # overlap (sharing a point counts): extend the
        # last one
        if out and s <= out[-1][1]:
            out[-1][1] = max(out[-1][1], e)
        else:
            out.append([s, e])
    return out
```

```
# FOLLOW-UP 2: Intervals: insert one new interval into an
# already merged list (LeetCode 57).
# Answer: Copy intervals ending before the new one, merge
# the ones that overlap it, then copy the rest. O(n), no
# sort needed.
def insert_interval(merged, new):
    # LeetCode 57: the list is already merged and sorted:
    # O(n)
    out, i, n = [], 0, len(merged)
    # 1) intervals that end before the new one starts
```

```
    while i < n and merged[i][1] < new[0]:
        out.append(merged[i])
        i += 1
    # 2) intervals that overlap it are absorbed
    s, e = new
    while i < n and merged[i][0] <= e:
        s, e = min(s, merged[i][0]), max(e, merged[i][1])
        i += 1
    out.append([s, e])
    # 3) the rest comes after
    out += merged[i:]
    return out


if __name__ == "__main__":
    assert min_eating_speed([3, 6, 7, 11], 8) == 4
    assert min_eating_speed([30, 11, 23, 4, 20], 5) == 30
    assert min_eating_speed([30, 11, 23, 4, 20], 6) == 23
    # fewer hours than piles: impossible
    assert min_eating_speed([1, 1, 1], 2) == -1
    assert hours_needed([3, 6, 7, 11], 4) == 8
    spans = [[1, 3], [2, 6], [8, 10], [15, 18]]
    merged = merge_intervals(spans)
    assert merged == [[1, 6], [8, 10], [15, 18]]
    assert merge_intervals([[1, 4], [4, 5]]) == [[1, 5]]
    assert merge_intervals([]) == []
    got = insert_interval([[1, 3], [6, 9]], [2, 5])
    assert got == [[1, 5], [6, 9]]
    assert insert_interval([], [4, 8]) == [[4, 8]]
    assert insert_interval([[1, 2], [5, 6]], [3, 4]) == [
        [1, 2], [3, 4], [5, 6]]
```

FUNCTION AND TEST CASES

Signature

```
def solution(piles: list[int], h: int) -> int:
```

Sample call

```
solution([3, 6, 7, 11], 8)
```

Test cases

Input	Expected
([3, 6, 7, 11], 8)	4
([30, 11, 23, 4, 20], 5)	30